



St George statuette

△ **St George** slaying the dragon in an early 16th-century painting by Raphael

This dazzling reliquary features a statuette of England's patron saint, St George, astride his horse, trampling underfoot the dragon he is famous for slaying. The horse is chalcedony, clad with a jewel-encrusted enamel caparison and crested with rubies and pearls. The dragon, scaled with emeralds and ruby-studded, has a white enamel belly. St George's armour is minutely detailed and the helmet's visor may even be lifted to reveal his face, which resembles the work's commissioner, Duke Wilhelm V of Bavaria. The gold pedestal that supports knight, horse, and dragon is richly adorned with diamonds, rubies, emeralds, pearls, agate, opals, and other gems. A drawer decorated with the Bavarian coat of arms in sapphire and enamel contains the relics of St George.



St Alexandra – martyr, Roman empress, and wife of Diocletian

The original legend of St George and the dragon was brought back from the East and adapted by the European Crusaders. Various versions of the story are told and, while they may be viewed as pure fiction or as an allegorical account of Christianity's triumph over paganism, it is recorded that St George himself was a historical figure. While serving as a soldier in the Roman army, he was tortured and executed after refusing the Emperor

Diocletian's personal request to renounce his Christianity. Impressed by St George's faith, Diocletian's wife, the Empress Alexandra, converted to Christianity and was also executed. It is possible she is the origin of the "princess" the knight rescues in the legend. St George's tomb is located in Lydda, Palestine, and relics from his remains are preserved in holy sites all around the world.



A band of armed Crusaders embarking for the Holy Land, where the legend of St George originated, in an illuminated manuscript from the *Statutes of the Order of St Esprit*

It is not an impure idol, it is a pious memorial

Bernard of **Angers**
11th-century chronicler

Key dates

275 CE–2000s

